# REPORT OF THE INTER-PARLIAMENTARY UNION (IPU) PARLIAMENTARY MEETING AT THE TWENTY NINTH SESSION OF THE CONFERENCE OF THE PARTIES (COP29)

## 16TH AND 17TH NOVEMBER 2024

## BAKU, AZERBAIJAN

## 1.0 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Speaker of Parliament, Hon. Advocate Jacob Francis Nzwidamilimo Mudenda, attended the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU) Parliamentary Meeting on the occasion of Twenty Ninth Session of the Conference of the Parties (COP29) held on 16 and 17 November 2024. He was accompanied by the following Chairpersons who were also part of the National delegation to COP29:

- ✓ Hon. Priscah Mupfumira, Member of Parliament and Chairperson of the Thematic Committee on Climate Change, and;
- ✓ Hon. Samson Matema, Member of Parliament and Chairperson of the Portfolio Committee on Environment, Climate and Wildlife.

1.2 The Parliamentary Meeting at COP29, jointly organized by the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU) and the Milli Mijlis (Parliament of Azerbaijan), brought together over 300 Parliamentarians, including Speakers from 61 countries.

1.3 Since the Copenhagen COP15 in 2009, the IPU has facilitated collaboration among Members of Parliament at annual UN climate meetings, promoting global coordination, sharing best practices and providing a Parliamentary perspective on climate change adaptation and action negotiations.

1.4 This year marks the second consecutive time the IPU has held its meeting at the site of the COP29 conference, reinforcing the centrality of Parliamentary involvement in the Climate Change dialogue. Additionally, this is the first time that the Parliamentary meeting was held over a two-day period, an evolution from half day to one day meetings in the past. The IPU has consistently emphasized the vital role of Parliaments globally in addressing Climate Change exigencies through effective legislation, green budgeting, and rigorous oversight of government commitments towards ameliorating climate change impacts. To that an extent, the recent launch of the IPU's climate campaign, **"Parliaments for the Planet,"** further underscores IPU's dedication to fostering meaningful climate action within the Parliamentary legislative processes.

## 2.0 COURTESY CALL ON HER EXCELLENCY SPEAKER GAFAROVA, SPEAKER OF THE PARLIAMENT OF AZERBAIJAN

2.1 On the 18th November 2024, Speaker Mudenda interfaced with his counterpart, Her Excellency Speaker Gafarova at the Milli Majlis (Parliament) Building. In a highly interactive session, the two Speakers

shared perspectives on wide ranging issues of mutual interest including the need to accentuate the existing cordial relations between Azerbaijan and Zimbabwe through exploring possible areas of cooperation, climate change within the context of discussions emanating from the Parliamentary Meeting on the occasion of COP29, harnessing Artificial Intelligence (AI) in a responsible manner in tackling climate action digitally. Consequently, both Speakers agreed that law making was a key role of Parliaments because the rule of law was a condition precedent for peace, order and good governance in pursuit of national development.

2.2 With regards to cultural exchanges between the people of Azerbaijan and Zimbabwe, both Speakers agreed that cultural ensemble exchange tours by both countries could revamp the cordial relations between the two sister Republics. In this vein, Speaker Mudenda proposed synergies with the trailblazing gastronomy initiative by the First Lady of Zimbabwe, Her Excellency, Dr Amai Mnangagwa, who has taken the Africa cuisine to elevated international levels as demonstrated by the United Nations Gastronomy Fair held in the resort City of Victoria Falls recently, courtesy of her initiative.

2.3 Finally, the Host Speaker and Speaker Mudenda resolved to establish a Parliamentary Friendship Association between the two Legislatures. Furthermore, Speaker Mudenda proposed benchmarking visits between the two Parliaments in order to share best Parliamentary practices for best Parliamentary processes. In this regard, he extended an invitation to Members of the Azerbaijan/Zimbabwe Parliamentary Friendship Association to visit Zimbabwe in the first quarter of 2025. That would be followed by reciprocal exchange visits by both Speakers.

## 3.0 OFFICIAL OPENING OF THE IPU PARLIAMENTARY MEETING

3.1 In welcoming delegates to the occasion, Her Excellency Sahiba Gafarova, Speaker of the Milli Majlis (Parliament) of the Republic of Azerbaijan emphasised that the entire global community was negatively impacted by climate change as evidenced by the unprecedented and catastrophic climate change disasters which include extreme weather patterns, food insecurities and water shortages, among others. In this regard, she called for immediate Global Parliamentary Action to address one of the pressing issues of our time. Furthermore, Speaker Gafarova called for Parliaments to play an active role in legislating for the benefit of the people as well as allocating sufficient

budgets to support Government initiatives towards positive climate change responses. To that an extent, she encouraged Parliaments to urge Governments to fulfil internationally agreed commitments.

3.2 Echoing the same sentiments, Her Excellency Dr. Tulia Ackson, President of the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU), reaffirmed the IPU's commitment to strengthening Parliaments' ability to address climate change impacts through advocacy and empowerment of legislators to ensure that voices of the people are heard. In furtherance to this, Parliaments must align related climate change legislation to global climate change goals. Accordingly, she called on Parliaments to make climate change adaption, mitigation, resilience and climate finance policies a priority at all societal levels, Parliaments must, therefore, enact and enforce climate change legislation in order to contain the devastating climate change impacts.

3.3 Addressing the same occasion, His Excellency, Mr. Mukhtar Babayev, President Designate of COP29 Assembly, acknowledged the pivotal role that Parliaments played in the adoption of the Financing Agreements. In the same vein, he implored Parliaments worldwide to continue demanding accountability for climate commitments from Governments, particularly on the implementation of climate financing in line with expectations of the people they represent, especially those in the Global South who are victims of greenhouse emissions from the Global North. Such collaborative efforts, he posited, will secure peace and prosperity for the well-being of humanity.

3.4 In introducing the special guest Speaker Mr. Simon Stiell, Mr. Martin Chungong, Secretary General of the IPU, urged Parliaments to make use of the IPU's 10 Action Points in order to shape policies that protect the environment for posterity.

3.5 His Excellency, Mr. Simon Stiell, urged Parliaments to take the lead in championing for concrete actions on climate change, emphasizing that the world now needs exponential action as opposed to the current trend of inertia. Furthermore, he noted the need to accelerate the finalization of the Nationally Determined Contributions by respective countries as well as implementing measures for affordable green energy.

## 4.0 SETTING THE SCENE: UNDERSTANDING THE REAL IMPACT OF CLIMATE CHANGE

4.1 After the formalities of the opening ceremony, the meeting shifted to the order of the day kickstarting with a session entitled ***"Setting the scene: understanding the real impact of climate change."*** Representatives of

people living on the frontlines of climate change, including youth, indigenous people and agents from the most vulnerable countries, particularly the small Island States took the floor to share their lived experiences. The low-lying islands in the Pacific and Indian Oceans are experiencing the brunt of devastating climate disasters, characterized by loss of ocean biodiversity, rise in sea levels, salty water tables which makes agriculture impermissible. This phenomenon has been described as climate injustice given the low levels of green house gas emissions by the Island countries compared to the developed world. The representatives shared that the Islands are now looking at climate adaptation which involves infrastructure development, building sea walls and migrating people. In some Island States adaptation and mitigation measures are no longer possible. Resultantly, whole States may lose their sovereignty when they migrate. Accordingly, Parliaments were called upon to take immediate action to protect the most vulnerable members of the communities. In the same vein, developed countries were urged to honour their Loss and Damage Fund commitments which were made in previous COP sessions.

4.2 In the spirit of inclusivity, young people were given an opportunity to share their thoughts on climate change impacts. The representative appealed to Parliaments to put children and young people at the centre of climate change given that children were at risk of loss of education and other essential services such as health and security.

4.3 Finally, Mr. Thomas Fitzgerald of the IPU Communication Department shared the IPU's campaign entitled, ***Parliaments for the Planet Campaign***, articulated the Ten (10) Action Points for Greener Parliaments as follows:

1. Track emissions from parliament's operations and set clear targets to reduce them;
2. Promote transparency in the greening process;
3. Strive for climate-resilient parliamentary operations;
4. Make sure parliamentary business is conducted in sustainable, water- and energy-efficient premises;
5. Implement green procurement policies;
6. Make parliament's transportation sustainable;
7. Embrace digitalization;
8. Foster a culture of sustainability and climate awareness;

9. Become a climate champion; and
10. Prioritize collaboration and knowledge-sharing.

4.4 Thereafter, participants shared experiences and best practices on the following topics:

- ✓ Making Climate Commitments a reality: Parliaments' Role in raising mitigation ambitions and implementing Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs);
- ✓ Unpacking the global climate finance architecture: Mobilizing resources and streamlining access to climate finance;
- ✓ Enhancing resilience in the face of climate change: scaling up adaptation and local empowerment of communities;
- ✓ Addressing climate vulnerability: Promoting a comprehensive and equitable approach to climate action;
- ✓ Harnessing technology to tackle climate change and ensuring fair access to digital technologies;
- ✓ Efforts to safeguard health and food security in the face of a changing climate; and
- ✓ Navigating human mobility and climate change: addressing climate-induced migration and displacement.

4.5 Hon. Matema, was a panelist during the Session entitled "**Unpacking The Global Climate Finance Architecture: Mobilizing Resources And Streamlining Access to Climate Finance"** where he shared Zimbabwe's experience and legislative measures taken to ameliorate against the debilitating effects of climate change in Zimbabwe. Concomitantly, Honorable Matema emphasized the urgent necessity of addressing the divide between the Global North and Global South, particularly regarding financial responsibilities for climate action. He argued that the Global North, which has historically contributed the most to greenhouse gas emissions, must take on a greater share of the financial burden needed to combat climate change impacts. This call for increased financial support is echoed in various international climate agreements, such as the Paris Agreement, where developed nations pledged to provide $100 billion annually to assist developing countries in their climate initiatives, but in vain.

4.5.1 Additionally, Honorable Matema referenced Zimbabwe's constitutional mandate which encourages citizens to safeguard the environment for future generations augmented by comprehensive interventions aimed at mitigatory measures for posterity. This principle is reflected in recent policies, including Statutory Instrument 150 of 2024, which focuses on carbon credits, as a measure for domestic resource mobilisation. This framework aims to create financial incentives for reducing emissions while promoting sustainable practices wherein local communities in Zimbabwe are being encouraged to engage in reforestation projects that not only help mitigate climate change but also provide economic benefits through carbon credit sales. Ultimately, Hon Matema made a clarion call for participants to realize that posterity will condemn the current generation for not doing enough to safeguard the protection of the environment. He thus called for robust financing models to ensure that set financial targets are met.

## 5.0 OUTCOME DOCUMENT

5.1 At the conclusion of the highly interactive deliberations, Hon. Soltan Mammadov, Rapporteur and Member of the Milli Majilis (Parliament) of the Republic of Azerbaijan, expressed confidence that the Outcome Document captured the key climate change issues from IPU Member Parliaments. He further explained that the Outcome Document was a result of an extensive consultation process and cooperation among IPU Parliaments as co-ordinated by the IPU Secretariat at the 149th Assembly of the IPU and Related Meetings held in Geneva, Switzerland in October 2024. The Rapporteur further proposed the inclusion of some key aspects emanating from the rich engagements during the sessions as well as bilateral discussions on the sidelines of the IPU Meeting which included harnessing positive emerging technologies such as AI to address the devastating impacts of climate change.

5.2 Accordingly, the final outcome document calls on Parliaments to, among others,

- ✓ Encourage governments to invest more in “accelerating the transition to clean, in particular renewable, energy” as well as renew “efforts to transition towards clean energy systems through gradual transition from fossil fuels and inefficient fossil fuel subsidies in a just, orderly and equitable manner.”
- ✓ Support governments in reducing non-CO2 emissions, especially methane, and to include specific targets in that regard in their national

climate commitments, known as Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs).

- ✓ With climate finance high on the agenda at COP29, Members of Parliament underlined the critical importance for developed countries to fulfil their financial commitments to enhance climate financing for developing nations and to urgently transfer loss and damage funding to vulnerable countries.
- ✓ Urged parliaments to employ artificial intelligence in tackling climate action while minimizing its risks, thereof..

## 6.0 CLOSING REMARKS

6.1 At the closure of the IPU meeting, Mr. Martin Chungong, IPU Secretary General, lauded the positive trajectory of the Parliamentary COP Meetings which have evolved from half day meetings to the historic two-day meeting. This is clear testimony of the IPU Member Parliaments' commitment to contributing towards finding global resolutions in response to the emerging climate change issues. He described the Outcome Document as a roadmap for immediate Parliamentary action to combat the devastating effects of climate change phenomenon which threatens the wellbeing of humanity.

6.2 Accordingly, he implored IPU Member Parliaments to take positive action in support of their Governments in the holistic implementation of the Paris Agreement underpinned by the Katowice Protocol. Additionally, the IPU Secretary General Mr Chungong also urged Parliaments to legislate for positive use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) while at the same time contending with the possible risks that AI may pose from time to time.

6.3 At the behest of the IPU President Ms Tulia Ackson and Azerbaijan Speaker, Her Excellency, Speaker Gafarova, the Parliamentary Meeting on the occasion of COP29 was officially closed by the IPU Secretary General on 17 November 2024, with a pledge to resume deliberations in Brazil at COP30 in 2025 where all IPU Member Parliaments where encouraged to attend.

## 7.0 RECOMMENDATIONS

7.1 The delegation wishes to applaud Parliament of Zimbabwe for capacitating all Members of Parliament on Climate Change. This is an essential step in ensuring that climate related reports are effectively debated in the house and

recommendations emanating from international conferences are implemented to such an extent possible. However, capacity building is a continual process. The Parliamentary Committees should, therefore, identify gaps and collaborate with the Ministry of Environment and other stakeholders including the IPU and Development Partners for future training needs.

7.2 The full text of the Outcome Document of the Parliamentary Meeting on the occasion of COP29 has been circulated to all Parliamentary Committees. Accordingly, the recommendations emanating from the Outcome Document should be implemented wherever possible. Furthermore, the relevant Parliamentary Committees should take a heightened role in climate change issues in order to improve oversight on climate change impacts.

7.3 Parliament should utilize IPU resources such as the **10 Actions for Greener Parliaments** and the Parliament for the Planet campaign to promote sustainable practices within Parliament and to advocate for similar practices within Government institutions. Additionally, the new toolkit, Parliamentary oversight of national climate commitments will enhance Parliamentary oversight of the NDCs. These resources are essential for ensuring that countries meet their obligations under the Paris Agreement which aims to limit global warming to 1.5°C.

7.4 Advocate for robust Climate Change Act which sets out clear emission reduction targets, establish legal framework for adaptation measures and define enforcement mechanisms.

## 8.0 CONCLUSION

8.1 The Delegation extends its profound gratitude to the Government of Zimbabwe and to Parliament for affording it the opportunity to represent Zimbabwe at such high-profile IPU Parliamentary Meeting at COP29.